Theosis

Summary

Theosis, called **the Gilded Suspension**, is a captured sulfur world whose immense sealed cities remain suspended within a lethal sulfur-dioxide atmosphere. Breathable air provides much of their lift, while heated chambers, gravitic stabilizers, structural frames, pressure membranes, altitude engines, and continuous labor keep nearly two billion residents from descending into the clouds below.

Theosis is the corporate homeworld and intersystem headquarters of Erbium Industries LLC. The company selected the planet as its permanent seat after the destruction of Wander, then constructed a civilization in which employment, housing, life support, finance, law, and government became functions of the same institution.

Erbium governs Theosis openly through the **Theosis Directorate**. Local councils possess meaningful municipal authority, but the corporation appoints the planetary executive, owns or certifies most essential infrastructure, controls the government's principal budgets and records, and maintains a permanent seat on the council responsible for drafting the Settled Systems Administrative Code.

ⓘ **THEOSIS**

The Gilded Suspension

Gravity Approximately 0.59 standard gravity; inhabited districts generally maintain between 0.6 and 0.9 standard gravity through local stabilization
Atmosphere Approximately 1 bar of sulfur dioxide outside the cities; breathable and mechanically regulated within inhabited envelopes
Day 11,760 stamp-offset minutes, divided locally into eight 1,470-minute civic bands
Year 1,322,496 stamp-offset minutes, approximately 918.4 standard days
Government Erbium Industries corporatocracy administered through the Theosis Directorate, Assembly of Envelopes, Common Altitude Board, and local Envelope Councils
Capital Crown Meridian
Corporate Headquarters Erbium Central
Population Approximately 1.86 billion; primarily human and dwarf, with substantial communities from throughout the Settled Systems
Languages Common, Dwarven, and most major Settled Systems languages
Religions Star Dream civic traditions, Wander memorial observances, corporate continuity doctrine, Vuddarian stewardship practices, industrial oath traditions, and imported Settled Systems faiths

Theosis fills an arriving vessel's forward windows long before any city becomes visible. Its atmosphere forms a dense globe of sulfurous white, ochre, and yellow-gray cloud wrapped in the changing light of the Alpha Leonis system. The world's steeply inclined retrograde orbit produces unfamiliar stellar movement, while its extreme axial orientation causes illuminated cloud bands to cross the planet at angles that make ordinary planetary navigation feel subtly wrong.

The buoyant cities appear only after a vessel descends into the upper atmosphere. They emerge as dark industrial silhouettes between layers of cloud: enormous lifting envelopes, trussed habitation blocks, pressure cylinders, stabilizer vanes, docking spines, thermal exchangers, cargo frames, and altitude engines connected through kilometers of reinforced structure.

From a distance, the largest aerostats resemble artificial islands. At close range, their scale becomes difficult to understand. Whole districts occupy separate pressure compartments. Freight trains cross enclosed bridges. Docking towers extend into calmer atmospheric bands. External maintenance crews travel across the hull through tether systems, sealed crawlways, and temporary work cages while sulfur clouds move beneath them fast enough to strip unsecured equipment from its mountings.

Visitors normally arrive through Theosis Way Station, where vessels undergo inspection, cargo balancing, customs review, and atmospheric-entry certification. Descent craft then dock at hardened transfer towers projecting above the inhabited envelopes.

Passengers pass through sulfur decontamination, pressure equalization, identity verification, and gravitic acclimation before entering city transit.

The first air they breathe on Theosis has usually been filtered, reclaimed, monitored, allocated, and billed several times before reaching them.

A Captured World

Theosis follows a steeply inclined, retrograde, and eccentric orbit associated with the shared gravitational structure of Alpha Leonis B and Alpha Leonis C. Its atmospheric planners track the changing positions of all three major stars, though most local orbital forecasts focus on the smaller pair and the barycentric path through which Theosis moves.

The planet has a radius of approximately 6,950 kilometers and a mass of approximately 4.22×10^{24} kilograms. Surface gravity is approximately 0.59 standard gravity. The weak magnetic field offers limited protection against stellar radiation, requiring the cities to incorporate radiation shielding, storm forecasting, and hardened electrical systems.

The atmosphere consists almost entirely of sulfur dioxide at approximately one bar of pressure. No established natural biosphere or open hydrosphere exists. Beneath the clouds lie sulfur plains, volcanic shelves, impact basins, chemically altered mineral fields, and exposed rock subjected to continuous corrosive weather.

Automated surface installations extract minerals, collect atmospheric samples, operate navigation beacons, and support research. Even specialized machines experience rapid material degradation. External seals harden, joints accumulate sulfur compounds, sensor apertures cloud, and exposed wiring requires frequent replacement.

The surface remains useful as a resource site and dangerously unsuitable as a place to live.

Theosis continues to be legally classified as a moon.

The designation originated with an early survey database that placed captured barycentric bodies within a satellite registry regardless of whether they orbited a planet. Correcting it would require amendments to centuries of property records, insurance agreements, environmental licenses, transportation certificates, loan instruments, and corporate charters.

Erbium standards authorities acknowledge that the designation is astronomically obsolete. They maintain it in the name of technical interoperability.

Formal documents therefore identify Theosis as **Alpha Leonis Captured Moon Four**. Residents call it a planet unless speaking to an insurer, customs officer, registry clerk, or court.

Time on Theosis

Theosis completes one local rotation every 11,760 stamp-offset minutes, equivalent to 196 standard hours. The natural day is far longer than the ordinary waking cycle of any major resident ancestry.

Local civil systems divide each rotation into eight **civic bands** of 1,470 minutes. Atmospheric forecasts, altitude adjustments, public transportation, schools, municipal services, and local observances are organized by band.

The eight bands are traditionally grouped into four broad civic periods:

- **Rising Operations**, when offices, schools, markets, and freight systems begin their principal activity;
- **Full Operations**, when most administrative and commercial work occurs;
- **Dimming Operations**, when services rotate, public lighting softens, and one portion of the population enters its principal rest cycle;
- **Quiet Operations**, when maintenance, sanitation, cargo transfer, and emergency testing dominate the city.

These periods describe administrative load rather than planetary sunrise. Different districts and professions remain active throughout all eight bands.

Erbium’s intersystem legal, financial, and administrative systems continue to use the 1,440-minute standard day. A civic band is thirty minutes longer. Residents employed in corporate administration frequently maintain separate local, corporate, and raw-stamp schedules.

The discrepancy affects more than convenience. A shift can begin within one local band and end during another corporate payroll day. A maintenance operation can satisfy an atmospheric deadline while missing an Erbium filing window. A worker can complete an extended forge watch and discover that a portion of it crossed a service-credit boundary without the correct authorization.

During relay interruptions, disagreements between local records and the recognized stamp authority can turn completed labor into ghost minutes.

Dwarven clanholdings maintain overlapping **forge watches** that provide uninterrupted structural coverage. Each watch includes inspectors, pressure engineers, stabilizer crews, emergency riggers, atmospheric pilots, and reserve personnel. Traditional forge-watch records are signed by the workers present and preserved in independent clan archives in addition to being stamped through corporate systems.

Theosis completes one orbit every 1,322,496 stamp-offset minutes, approximately 918.4 standard days. The world completes about twelve and two-thirds local orbits during one standard lapse.

Residents use local years for atmospheric planning, family anniversaries, school terms, and Shredder forecasting. Intersystem law, corporate history, contracts, and government records use Post-Erbium Standard.

The campaign begins at `29:08472119 PES`.

Before the Stamp

Theosis was surveyed during the first centuries of the interstellar era, after the Star Dream connected the early Elect civilizations and long before the establishment of PES.

Early probes classified it as a chemically hostile captured world with limited settlement potential. Its sulfur atmosphere, low surface gravity, weak magnetic field, extreme axial orientation, and unusual orbit made ordinary surface colonization commercially unattractive.

Erbium engineers identified a different use.

Breathable atmosphere is significantly lighter than sulfur dioxide. A sufficiently large sealed habitat could use the air inside it as a lifting medium. Heated chambers, variable ballast, altitude engines, and gravitic stabilization would still be necessary, but the atmosphere required to keep residents alive could also help hold their city above the surface.

The first Erbium installations were described as atmospheric laboratories, fuel stations, and relay-support platforms. Their actual design included redundant archives, secure communications, emergency power, refined-material storage, and executive habitation.

The company had begun evaluating Theosis as a corporate continuity site before Wander's destruction.

Erbium's official histories describe this as ordinary disaster preparedness. Independent historians point to the timing and content of early shipments. Legal archives, private communications systems, financial records, refined erbium reserves, construction machinery, and specialized personnel arrived before the general public understood the severity of Wander's instability.

Theosis was never large enough to evacuate Wander.

It was already prepared to preserve Erbium.

The Second Home

Construction convoys departed for Theosis within months of Wander's collapse.

The first arrivals included Erbium continuity personnel, engineers, corporate officials, relay technicians, financial administrators, legal archivists, dwarven structural crews, displaced workers, and refugees selected for technical or political usefulness.

Temporary atmospheric platforms expanded into permanent pressure habitats. Permanent habitats were connected around shared structural frames. Within the first generation after the collapse, the largest installation had become **Crown Meridian**.

Its oldest compartments contained relay archives, emergency reserves, executive offices, legal records, atmosphere laboratories, and the command systems coordinating Erbium's surviving operations.

Erbium presented Theosis as a second home for the displaced peoples of Wander.

Refugees were offered transport, employment, pressure-rated housing, medical care, and participation in the construction of a shared interstellar future. Most arrived under emergency employment agreements. Their housing depended on service. Their equipment was leased. Transportation became debt. The atmosphere outside made withdrawal from corporate infrastructure functionally impossible.

The first permanent municipal offices developed from worksite administration. Housing officers became residency authorities. Atmospheric engineers became regulators. Security supervisors became civil enforcement officials. Corporate mediators became judges.

The distinction between employer and government never developed because the same institution built both.

Erbium transferred its formal headquarters to Crown Meridian within the early reconstruction period. Its governing board, strategic-reserve authority, relay administration, legal divisions, financial offices, and senior engineering institutions followed.

Theosis became the first world where Erbium did not need to influence an existing government.

It constructed a government around its own operational structure.

The War of the Open Stars

By the time Zakaron began its expansion, Theosis had already served as Erbium's headquarters for generations.

Crown Meridian coordinated coalition supply agreements, military financing, relay access, refugee movement, erbium allocations, ship repair, and diplomatic communication during the War of the Open Stars.

Theosis was geographically and politically suited to serve as the coalition's administrative center. Its hostile atmosphere limited unauthorized access. Its cities were owned or controlled by Erbium. Its relay systems were among the most secure outside Wander's former system. Its legal offices already managed agreements among governments dependent on corporate infrastructure.

The war accelerated the growth of the buoyant cities. New aerostats housed military logistics, refugee populations, clerical divisions, weapons insurers, shipyard personnel, and the expanding bureaucracies needed to coordinate intersystem conflict.

The Still-Drive negotiations were conducted through Theosis legal, financial, and communications infrastructure.

When the Still-Drive Accords became effective at `0:00000000 PES`, Erbium activated the new universal time standard through its relay network and presented Theosis as the administrative center of the peace.

For Zakaron, the first stamp recorded the moment its expansion stopped.

For Erbium, it recorded the moment a corporate emergency authority became the timekeeper and legal convenor of interstellar civilization.

The PES Era

The first lapses after the Accords were devoted to standardization.

Wander technical records, Erbium operating rules, military logistics agreements, Theosis municipal regulations, intersystem treaties, and emergency protocols were reorganized into the earliest versions of the Settled Systems Administrative Code.

Theosis expanded with that legal system. Every new intersystem obligation created new offices, archives, courts, credentialing boards, and professional institutions. Crown Meridian became the center of corporate law and finance, while other aerostats specialized in engineering, education, logistics, medicine, atmosphere research, and administration.

Several major disasters shaped modern Theosis.

During Lapse 7, three linked habitation compartments lost structural synchronization during periastron atmospheric compression. Emergency crews preserved the central city by detaching two failing districts. More than eighty thousand residents died during the descent.

The disaster led to the formal adoption of Settled Systems Code `A1%8&14-7`, the **Pressure-Envelope Inspection Record Standard**. The provision requires compatible stamped maintenance histories for certified pressure membranes, structural couplings, lift chambers, stabilizer systems, and emergency separation assemblies.

The law allows inspectors to compare parts and repair histories across manufacturers and has prevented repeated failures. It also makes independent work dependent on Erbium-compatible documentation. Repairs recorded only through local logs, clan archives, or off-stamp systems may be treated as unverified.

During Lapse 18, a failed stabilization network placed several cities on converging altitude paths. Emergency authorities redirected one populated industrial district into a lower atmospheric band to protect three larger settlements. The district survived for nearly four standard days before its envelopes failed.

The resulting Settled Systems Code `A9%6&12-2`, the **Aerostat Compartment Separation Authority**, permits designated infrastructure officers to sever a district, pressure compartment, docking assembly, or structural frame when its continued connection presents a credible danger to a larger inhabited system.

The provision has saved millions of residents. Lower industrial districts carry most of the equipment, ballast, cargo, and structural connections that emergency planners are willing to sacrifice.

By Lapse 29, Theosis has become one of the wealthiest and most politically influential worlds in the Settled Systems.

Its wealth rests inside cities whose survival margins are continuously calculated, certified, financed, and revised.

The Buoyant Cities

The buoyant cities use breathable air as their principal lifting medium. Their inhabited volumes displace heavier sulfur dioxide and generate natural buoyancy. Heated lift chambers, variable ballast, gravitic stabilizers, atmospheric control surfaces, altitude engines, and structural frames provide maneuverability and compensate for changes in weight.

Every resident, room, cargo container, water tank, vehicle, and machine affects a city's balance.

Theosis planners discuss inhabited space in terms of:

- breathable volume;
- lift contribution;
- structural burden;
- pressure redundancy;
- evacuation capacity;
- stabilizer demand;
- atmosphere-processing load;
- certified resident allocation.

A spacious public hall contributes lift while increasing the amount of envelope surface requiring inspection. A dense industrial compartment adds weight and power demand while supporting the engines and ballast systems that maintain altitude.

The largest cities consist of several linked envelopes. Each envelope contains semi-independent pressure compartments capable of being isolated during a failure. Transfer locks, atmosphere gates, blast doors, emergency masks, and separation collars appear throughout ordinary public architecture.

Upper districts occupy the most stable and desirable buoyancy bands. They contain administrative campuses, prestigious schools, controlled gardens, private medical facilities, financial institutions, legal offices, diplomatic residences, and housing insulated from industrial noise. Their pressure systems use newer components and contain extensive redundancy.

Middle districts contain most ordinary housing, shops, schools, clinics, public offices, transit stations, workshops, food production, and service employment. A family may live in the same compartment for generations while possessing only a renewable occupancy credential.

Lower decks contain ballast systems, freight yards, waste processing, water recovery, cargo infrastructure, pressure-envelope access, stabilizer assemblies, external locks, altitude engines, heat exchangers, and emergency separation mechanisms. Housing there is cheaper and more vulnerable to chemical contamination, vibration, power interruption, and evacuation.

Settled Systems Code `A4%7&14-3`, the **Pressure-Rated Habitation Eligibility and Transitional Continuity Provision**, requires every occupant of a certified residential compartment to possess an employment, dependent, educational, medical, civic, or private sponsorship category linked to evacuation and life-support planning.

The law gives emergency personnel accurate records of who lives in each compartment and what assistance they require.

It also allows Erbium and affiliated landlords to treat loss of employment as loss of residential eligibility.

A separated employee is formally entitled to a transitional review. Safety, identity, capacity, and sponsor-verification exceptions can shorten the review period. Workers can retain planetary residency while losing access to the pressure-rated compartment in which that residency is supposed to exist.

Air, altitude, and housing are related forms of property on Theosis.

The Shredder Passage

Theosis's eccentric orbit repeatedly carries it through a period of rapid change in stellar heating and atmospheric circulation.

The formal term is **periastron atmospheric compression**. Residents call it the **Shredder Passage**.

The planet remains gravitationally intact. The danger comes from the atmosphere.

Cloud layers expand, contract, and change altitude. Wind velocity increases. Shear develops between atmospheric bands moving in different directions. Reliable buoyancy zones migrate. Cities must alter altitude, orientation, ballast distribution, stabilizer output, and external configuration while carrying entire populations through the disturbance.

Preparation begins thousands of minutes before the calculated approach.

Cities:

- retract exposed structures;
- redistribute freight and ballast;
- inspect docking collars;
- seal external maintenance sections;
- fill emergency pressure reservoirs;
- reinforce intercity connections;
- test compartment doors;
- reconfigure solar infrastructure;
- verify separation systems;
- position rescue vessels;
- restrict unnecessary movement.

Settled Systems Code `A5%11&9-4`, the **Periastron Port Suspension and Atmospheric Docking Restriction**, suspends ordinary atmospheric arrivals, departures, and external intercity docking during declared Shredder conditions.

The restriction prevents vessels from colliding with moving cities or transferring dangerous forces through docking structures. It can also strand passengers in orbit, interrupt medicine deliveries, delay reorientation journeys, generate storage charges, and leave employees unable to reach the city where their housing remains registered.

Upper districts experience the Shredder Passage through reinforced observation galleries, carefully staged public broadcasts, remote work periods, and educational programs explaining atmospheric engineering. Private viewings allow residents to watch distant aerostats shift between bands of illuminated cloud.

Lower-deck residents hear stabilizers change load through the walls. Cargo strains against restraints. Pressure doors remain sealed for extended periods. Maintenance workers sleep beside their stations, and families keep evacuation masks within reach.

Dwarven forge watches form a large part of the Shredder workforce. Their crews inspect frames, reinforce structural nodes, monitor fatigue, coordinate altitude adjustments, repair stabilizers, and prepare to separate a failing compartment before its motion endangers the city.

Settled Systems Code `A4%5&18-6`, the **Periastron Continuity Labor Designation**, allows the planetary government and certified infrastructure operators to reassign qualified personnel, extend coverage periods, alter rest scheduling, and restrict departure during a declared recurring environmental hazard.

The law requires medical monitoring, replacement crews, and hazard compensation.

Erbium employment classifications define many Shredder duties as ordinary functions of pressure, structural, freight, atmospheric, and continuity personnel. Workers already assigned to those categories receive standard compensation for conditions that would generate hazard premiums for other employees.

The Erbium Corporatocracy

Theosis is governed by Erbium Industries LLC.

Corporate and planetary authority remain legally distinguishable for accounting, treaty, and jurisdictional purposes. Both answer to the same executive structure.

Erbium:

- appoints the planetary executive;
- operates the principal courts and archives;
- controls the government's major budgets;
- owns most strategic infrastructure;
- licenses essential professions;
- administers much of the public medical system;
- maintains planetary security;
- determines recognized pressure and engineering standards;
- controls Crown Meridian's principal housing portfolios;
- operates the relay and PES infrastructure;
- owns or certifies the equipment upon which the cities depend.

Erbium officials describe Theosis as a **stewarded corporatocracy**. Public materials emphasize that the institution responsible for keeping the cities alive must possess the authority to coordinate them.

Critics generally omit the adjective.

The Theosis Directorate

The **Theosis Directorate** is the planetary executive government.

The First Director is appointed by Erbium's governing board and normally holds a senior corporate operations position simultaneously. Most directorate officials are selected from corporate departments, professional boards, city administrations, and recognized technical institutions.

Directorate offices govern:

- altitude and atmospheric coordination;
- pressure-habitat certification;

- housing eligibility;
- public health and environmental medicine;
- civil security;
- transportation and docking;
- professional accreditation;
- education standards;
- taxation and corporate assessments;
- planetary courts;
- emergency planning;
- intersystem relations.

Directorate authority is strongest in subjects classified as infrastructure continuity. On Theosis, nearly every important political subject can acquire that classification.

The Assembly of Envelopes

The **Assembly of Envelopes** is the principal planetary legislature.

Every recognized aerostat sends delegates according to population, certified habitation volume, infrastructure contribution, and corporate charter status. Local Envelope Councils select most delegates. Erbium directly appoints additional continuity, finance, standards, and strategic-infrastructure representatives.

The appointed bloc cannot ordinarily govern alone. It is large enough that no planetary law can pass without some corporate support.

The Assembly debates housing rules, public services, school funding, medical access, city expansion, local taxation, worker protections, and municipal budgets. It can reject Directorate proposals, investigate failures, and impose conditions on public spending.

The Directorate can suspend an Assembly measure if it finds that the law conflicts with essential infrastructure, corporate charter obligations, recognized Settled Systems standards, or the safety of another aerostat.

The Common Altitude Board

The **Common Altitude Board** coordinates buoyancy bands, city movement, navigation corridors, stabilizer standards, atmospheric forecasting, and Shredder preparations.

Its members include engineers, meteorologists, pressure specialists, pilots, emergency planners, and civil administrators appointed through the Directorate, Assembly, professional boards, and major cities.

The Board possesses broad operational authority because two cities can endanger one another through poor coordination without either intending harm.

Its technical decisions also distribute political cost. Assigning one aerostat to a less stable band can protect several others. Ordering a city to descend can damage its envelopes, interrupt employment, lower property values, and expose its residents to greater risk.

The Board presents its models as objective. Every model depends on which populations and structures the government recognizes.

Envelope Councils

Each aerostat maintains an **Envelope Council** responsible for local housing, education, sanitation, public transit, markets, neighborhood development, municipal clinics, and ordinary emergency planning.

Some councils are directly elected. Others divide seats among residents, property holders, clanholdings, worker associations, and corporate charter institutions.

The councils possess meaningful authority. They can protect striking workers, subsidize clinics, preserve housing, expand schools, maintain independent records, and resist unpopular development.

Their decisions still require money, equipment, records, and enforcement systems controlled by Erbium.

Erbium Central

Erbium Central occupies the upper structural core of Crown Meridian.

The complex contains:

- Erbium’s governing board chambers;
- executive offices;
- the Theosis Directorate;
- the central legal archive;
- the strategic erbium reserve authority;
- PES oversight systems;
- intersystem financial administration;
- relay coordination;
- senior engineering authorities;
- Frontier Extraction Division command;
- the principal departments governing Drift infrastructure.

The visible campus is spacious, quiet, and meticulously maintained. Pale stone composites, controlled gardens, stable artificial gravity, clean geometric branding, and concealed service access present the institutional ideal of Erbium civilization.

Thousands of technicians work beneath the public campus. They maintain the pressure systems, data centers, power distribution, emergency reservoirs, cooling machinery, freight lifts, and structural frames that preserve its silence.

Erbium Central is both a corporate headquarters and a seat of government. Corporate policy can become planetary regulation without passing through an external sovereign authority.

Planetary practices developed on Theosis frequently become models for intersystem standards.

The Council of Settled Systems Administration

The **Council of Settled Systems Administration** drafts, negotiates, and amends the Settled Systems Administrative Code.

Recognized governments send delegations to the Council. Its provisions become binding through treaties, interoperability agreements, infrastructure licenses, local adoption, and the material requirements of participating in Settled Systems trade.

The Council meets in **Concordance Hall** within Erbium Central.

Erbium Industries holds a permanent voting position called the **Infrastructure Stewardship Seat**.

Settled Systems Code `A8%10&5-2`, the **Essential Infrastructure Stewardship Representation Provision**, guarantees representation to the recognized operator of intersystem relay synchronization, strategic erbium reserves, PES administration, and shared transportation standards.

The provision’s public purpose is to ensure that laws affecting essential infrastructure include technical participation from the institution expected to implement them.

Its practical effect is that Erbium votes directly on laws governing Erbium infrastructure, Erbium contracts, corporate employees, PES records, Drift access, and corporate authority.

Theosis also sends a planetary delegation selected through the Directorate and Assembly of Envelopes.

Erbium therefore influences the Council through its direct Stewardship Seat, its control of Theosis, its technical staff, and the dependency of other delegations on corporate infrastructure.

The company describes these as separate legal interests.

Other governments describe them as several chairs occupied by the same institution.

Political Tendencies

The **Board Continuity Caucus** includes Erbium executives, appointed Directorate officials, ladder families, senior legal authorities, insurance firms, and major financial institutions. It supports centralized administration, extensive continuity powers, and the continued integration of corporation and government.

Its members argue that Theosis is alive because Erbium can make rapid decisions across infrastructure, finance, labor, and law without waiting for jurisdictional disputes.

The **Municipal Envelope Bloc** represents elected councils from the major cities. It accepts Erbium's planetary sovereignty while seeking greater local control over housing, schools, clinics, policing, taxation, and maintenance budgets.

The **Holding Compact** represents dwarven clanholdings, independent engineering firms, professional inspectors, and skilled-worker associations. It seeks guaranteed repair funding, public access to maintenance records, stronger inspector authority, and limits on craft-warrant liability.

The **Breath Commons** argues that breathable habitation is a civic right. Its platform calls for permanent residency independent of corporate employment, public sponsorship of life-support allocations, transparent pressure-capacity data, and limits on housing removal during labor disputes.

The **Free Altitude League** represents semi-independent aerostats and small cities. It supports local control over housing, commerce, municipal law, and internal services while accepting central coordination of atmospheric safety.

The **Code Reform Delegation** opposes Erbium's permanent Stewardship Seat and Theosis's effective double representation on the Council of Settled Systems Administration. Its supporters include local reformers, foreign delegates, independent legal scholars, and Erbium officials who believe the current arrangement damages the legitimacy of the Code.

The **Public Systems Front** advocates transferring stabilizers, pressure networks, water systems, emergency equipment, and public housing into a worker- and municipality-controlled authority.

Its technical members possess detailed transition plans. Its radical wing believes Erbium will surrender control only after a planet-wide refusal of labor.

Humans of Theosis

Theosis contains one of the largest human populations in the Settled Systems.

Human ladder families dominate many upper-district schools, legal offices, financial institutions, professional boards, government departments, and corporate administrative divisions. Their children grow up with stable gravity, preventative medicine, private education, supervised internships, and an inherited familiarity with the social rules governing senior employment.

They also inherit networks established before PES. Some families trace their Theosis status to the corporate personnel selected for continuity transfer before Wander's collapse.

Corporate culture presents these households as proof that disciplined families produce qualified leadership.

Their ancestors helped determine which qualifications would matter.

Most humans on Theosis maintain the cities rather than administer them. They work as pressure technicians, cargo handlers, sanitation crews, transit operators, legal clerks, medical staff, stabilizer mechanics, housing administrators, construction workers, teachers, service personnel, and emergency responders.

Generations raised under reduced gravity are often taller and more lightly built. Compression garments, resistance training, skeletal scans, circulatory treatments, and joint medication are common.

Upper-district residents receive extensive preventative care.

Lower-deck workers frequently obtain treatment through employer clinics whose services depend on continued employment eligibility.

Theosis creates two widely recognized images of humanity.

Corporate media presents the polished official whose success demonstrates the fairness of Erbium advancement.

Workers throughout the Settled Systems recognize the exhausted technician whose family remains one missed shift away from losing pressure-rated housing.

Dwarves of Theosis

Dwarves form the second-largest ancestry population and maintain some of the oldest technical institutions on the planet.

The earliest dwarven crews arrived during the rapid construction following Wander's destruction. Their clans built pressure frames, docking collars, lift chambers, maintenance routes, stabilizer supports, and emergency separation systems that remain inside the oldest aerostats.

Many clans operate **clanholdings** combining residences, workshops, archives, legal representation, mutual-aid funds, shrines, social halls, and emergency shelter.

Forge watches allow dwarven crews to maintain continuous coverage across the 11,760-minute local rotation. Clan archives preserve maintenance records beyond the service lives of individual companies and computer systems.

Dwarven work marks appear throughout Theosis. Structures commonly bear the names and clan marks of the engineers who designed, inspected, repaired, or refused them.

Settled Systems Code `A3%8&16-5`, the **Certified Craft-Warrant Liability Allocation**, recognizes these marks as evidence that a qualified professional accepted responsibility for the condition disclosed during an inspection.

The provision was intended to prevent temporary contractors from disappearing after approving unsafe work.

Erbium and Directorate courts can assign liability to the signing engineer or clan when a system later fails, even when management rejected recommended repairs, substituted materials, altered stamped records, or continued operation past the disclosed service limit.

Dwarven inspectors increasingly attach independent counters, witnessed annotations, physical seals, and clan-held records to their work. Erbium compliance offices accept them as supplemental evidence while treating the corporate stamp as authoritative.

Some clanholdings cooperate closely with Erbium and regard the relationship as essential to the survival and prosperity of their members. Others maintain independent workshops, supply agreements, mutual-aid funds, and off-stamp archives intended to limit corporate control.

Most large clans contain both tendencies.

Other Residents

Every recognized Settled Systems ancestry maintains established communities on Theosis.

Android technicians work throughout control systems, data administration, external maintenance, medicine, and high-risk infrastructure. Their bodies are often well suited to reduced-gravity environments, though compatible components remain governed through Erbium leases and foundries.

Astrazoans are prominent in administration, secure service positions, performance, diplomacy, corporate representation, and older infrastructure requiring obsolete identities or biometric clearances.

Brenneri communities maintain enclosed aquatic districts, water cooperatives, medical practices, and social-support networks. The amount of water required by these communities makes their habitation politically visible.

Fonqugon analysts contribute to atmospheric forecasting, systems modeling, logistics, engineering review, and financial projections. Erbium frequently treats their ability to process several problems at once as justification for assigning several roles under one employment classification.

Lashuntas work throughout government, design, education, medicine, corporate service, communications, and public presentation. The upper districts strongly reward expressions regarded as professionally desirable.

Madrosarai firms provide surgical services, cybernetics, security, intelligence work, blood-reactive systems, and specialist medicine.

Moyishuu pilots support Drift traffic, orbital transfer, emergency passage, and stellar observation. Constellations frequently visit Theosis while avoiding permanent settlement inside its enclosed pressure environments.

Vesk crews work in heavy construction, freight, rescue, external security, stabilizer replacement, and emergency compartment entry.

Class, occupation, city, and sponsorship status shape daily life more strongly than ancestry alone. An upper-district nonhuman legal officer possesses more institutional security than a human pressure worker living beside an industrial envelope.

The Human Default still shapes most equipment, medicine, architecture, and procedure.

Life in Suspension

Theosis residents develop an intimate awareness of the machinery around them.

They recognize changes in ventilation pitch, stabilizer vibration, lift-chamber heat, pressure-door timing, and the movement of freight through the structure. Children learn atmosphere drills alongside reading and arithmetic. Households keep emergency masks accessible even in wealthy districts.

Silence has different meanings across the planet.

In Erbium Central, silence demonstrates successful engineering.

In a lower deck, silence can mean that a pump has stopped.

The distinction between public and industrial space is often thin. A market may occupy a former cargo junction. A school can share a pressure compartment with a water-processing system. Apartments are built around structural braces that cannot be moved. Maintenance crews pass through residential corridors to reach machinery installed before the housing existed.

Personal decoration accumulates around corporate standardization. Residents paint pressure doors, hang fabric over exposed frames, build gardens under service lamps, convert obsolete inspection plates into furniture, and preserve objects brought from Wander or later homeworlds.

Older districts contain generations of repair. A single wall can include Wander-manufactured supports, pre-PES Erbium plates, early Commonwealth seals, dwarven reinforcements, and recently printed polymer covers.

The Erbium emblem remains cleanest.

Breath, Water, and Status

Breathable air is abundant enough to lift cities and expensive enough to control their residents.

Atmospheric systems constantly reclaim oxygen, remove carbon dioxide, control humidity, monitor contaminants, and maintain pressure. Housing assessments include expected air demand, medical need, occupancy category, and evacuation priority.

Residents do not ordinarily pay for each breath. They pay for the infrastructure that makes breathing possible through rent, employment deductions, municipal assessments, medical classifications, and service eligibility.

Water is more visibly scarce.

Theosis possesses no open hydrosphere. Its cities rely on imported ice, chemical recovery, aggressive recycling, industrial synthesis, and carefully managed reserves.

Upper districts contain controlled gardens, reflecting pools, humid public spaces, and ornamental water. These features contribute to the image that Erbium created a prosperous home from a hostile world.

Lower districts use pressure-controlled allotments, communal reclamation systems, and strict recycling requirements.

Brenneri pools, hydroponic agriculture, medical facilities, and industrial processes compete for the same reserves. Water allocation debates often become ancestry, labor, housing, and class disputes simultaneously.

Corporate and Industrial Economy

Theosis specializes in administration supported by heavy infrastructure.

Its major industries include:

- intersystem finance;
- insurance;
- corporate law;
- arbitration;
- professional credentialing;
- pressure-habitat engineering;
- gravitic stabilization;
- atmospheric modeling;
- sulfur chemistry;
- high-output solar power;
- relay administration;

- PES synchronization;
- ship repair and refueling;
- cargo coordination;
- medical services for sealed environments;
- reduced-gravity medicine;
- corporate and technical education.

The world's wealthiest institutions occupy spacious upper compartments whose clean public surfaces conceal immense machinery below.

Corporate interiors use quiet ventilation, controlled lighting, pale materials, clean geometry, and concealed maintenance access. Every surface is intended to communicate stability.

Lower decks smell of machine oil, hot insulation, disinfectant, sulfur residue, reclaimed water, pressure fabric, electrical housings, and food stalls operating beside transit and maintenance routes.

The planet also exports expertise.

Engineers trained on Theosis work wherever people live inside hostile atmospheres, orbital habitats, pressure vessels, artificial-gravity structures, and industrial stations.

Erbium recruitment campaigns use images of Theosis technicians to represent competence, sacrifice, and the shared labor required to keep civilization alive.

The campaigns rarely identify who owns the air system behind the worker.

Public Ritual and Corporate Memory

Theosis presents itself as the civilization that rose after Wander.

The largest corporate observance is **Second Home Day**, which commemorates the arrival of the early construction fleets and the declaration that Erbium would rebuild a permanent home among the clouds.

Official ceremonies emphasize refugees, engineers, continuity personnel, and the company's preservation of interstellar civilization. Executive speeches are followed by worker commendations, archive displays, school performances, and the activation of enormous Erbium emblems across the upper cities.

Worker communities observe several less formal remembrances.

The Empty Berths honors those who were never evacuated from Wander. Families leave unused seats at communal meals or place unclaimed work tags beside memorial walls.

Separation Vigils commemorate districts detached during atmospheric emergencies. Cities dim external lights while surviving relatives read names over maintenance and emergency channels.

First Stamp marks the activation of PES and the end of the Zakaron war. Corporate ceremonies describe it as the beginning of shared intersystem civilization. Zakaron communities and political dissidents view the event differently.

Major Locations

Crown Meridian

Crown Meridian is the oldest buoyant city, capital of Theosis, and formal seat of Erbium Industries.

The city grew around a pre-PES continuity frame established before Wander's destruction. Its oldest structural core contains sealed archives, strategic reserves, relay systems, and machinery from the first settlement period.

Modern Crown Meridian contains the Theosis Directorate, Assembly of Envelopes, Common Altitude Board, major courts, diplomatic districts, corporate academies, financial institutions, and the principal offices of Erbium Industries.

Successive generations of expansion have produced an enormous vertical and structural hierarchy. New upper districts rest upon frames and machinery maintained by communities living several compartments below them.

Erbium Central

Erbium Central is the intersystem headquarters of Erbium Industries and the administrative center of Theosis.

Its upper campus contains executive offices, the governing board, strategic-reserve authorities, PES oversight, the Theosis Directorate, Frontier Extraction command, and Concordance Hall.

The visible headquarters is quiet, spacious, and precisely maintained. Its lower structural core contains pressure equipment, data centers, emergency bunkers, cooling systems, freight lifts, worker transit, and several generations of machinery.

The headquarters emblem remains illuminated during Shredder conditions unless power preservation reaches the highest emergency classification.

Concordance Hall

Concordance Hall contains the Council of Settled Systems Administration.

Its central chamber is surrounded by delegation suites, legal archives, translation systems, technical review offices, and secure relay facilities. Erbium's Infrastructure Stewardship Seat occupies a permanent position facing the rotating chair.

Public galleries allow visitors to observe formal sessions. Most significant agreements are negotiated in private technical committees before they reach the chamber.

Palladium Reach

Palladium Reach occupies Crown Meridian's highest stable habitation tier.

Prestigious academies, private clinics, executive residences, controlled gardens, legal institutes, and financial towers fill its interconnected pressure galleries.

Its expansive interior spaces contribute lift. Enormous ballast systems beneath the district compensate for the dense construction, private water reserves, and gravitic stabilization required to maintain its preferred environment.

The Keelworks

The Keelworks are Crown Meridian's lower industrial districts.

Cargo sorting, ballast control, sanitation, water recovery, stabilizer maintenance, heat exchange, waste processing, and emergency separation systems operate continuously.

Workers describe the Keelworks as the portion of the capital that knows its actual weight.

The district contains large human worker populations, multiple dwarven clanholdings, independent repair markets, union offices, communal kitchens, employer clinics, and housing attached to infrastructure service.

Tavran Brace

Tavran Brace is a major dwarven clanholding and structural works spanning several of Crown Meridian's oldest load-bearing frames.

Clan Tavran preserves inspection and repair records reaching into the pre-PES settlement period. Its engineers are known for refusing to approve work they cannot inspect fully.

The holding provides housing, legal support, training, emergency shelter, and medical assistance to clan members and affiliated workers.

Its current refusal to sign a major craft warrant has become a planetary political dispute.

Skinline Fourteen

Skinline Fourteen is a broad pressure-envelope maintenance zone on the underside of the city Gannet.

Crews work between the breathable inner membrane and corrosion-resistant external skin. Access requires sealed equipment, chemical protection, tether lines, and continuous atmospheric monitoring.

Much of the associated housing is classified as employment-adjacent because it lies inside the industrial pressure compartment.

Residents can lose both employment and immediate habitation eligibility through the same administrative action.

Osprey

Osprey is a semi-independent aerostat governed through an elected Envelope Council, resident cooperative, and worker-owned maintenance authority.

It purchases relay service, medical supplies, and specialized parts from Erbium while retaining local control of housing and life support.

Its survival is regularly cited by the Free Altitude League as evidence that municipal control is technically viable.

Osprey's stabilizers were produced by a manufacturer that no longer sells directly to cooperatives.

The Castoff Field

The Castoff Field is a drifting region of separated compartments, failed lift cells, abandoned freight assemblies, rescue platforms, and salvage yards occupying a relatively predictable lower-atmosphere current.

Some structures were evacuated before detachment. Others remain memorial sites.

Salvagers operate from pressure vessels, tethered platforms, and mobile lift cells while city governments, insurers, former residents, and Erbium creditors dispute ownership of surviving property.

Heliostat Bastion

Heliostat Bastion is the hardened orbital solar array supporting Theosis.

Its photovoltaic fields, storage systems, and transmission equipment are designed to survive changing stellar conditions. The installation provides emergency power, charges orbital reserves, supports the Way Station, and supplements city generation during Shredder preparations.

Radiation crews work among replacement panels from dozens of production generations.

Theosis Way Station

Theosis Way Station is the principal orbital repair, refueling, communications, and atmospheric-transfer facility.

Rotating habitation sections support approximately five hundred permanent personnel and several times that number during traffic surges. Descent craft, cargo modules, fuel reservoirs, repair gantries, and relay equipment surround its central structure.

During the Shredder Passage, stranded travelers can remain aboard long enough for temporary lodging and cargo-storage fees to exceed the price of their original passage.

Recent Events

At `29:07844206 PES`, an independent laboratory reported that several pressure membranes manufactured by Asterline Envelope Systems were aging faster than their certified fatigue models predicted.

Asterline disputes the testing methodology. The Directorate has ordered targeted inspections while resisting demands for a general evacuation that would displace more than forty million residents.

Tavran Brace has refused to sign a new craft warrant covering emergency repairs in Crown Meridian. Its engineers state that the proposed work can temporarily stabilize the frame but cannot support the service duration listed in the contract.

Erbium procurement authorities argue that refusing the warrant delays work essential to the capital's safety.

A work stoppage in the Keelworks has triggered habitation-eligibility reviews for thousands of employees and dependents. The Directorate has suspended immediate removals while maintaining that it cannot permanently allocate certified pressure volume to residents whose sponsor no longer contributes to city services.

The Breath Commons has introduced a measure declaring breathable residential volume an essential civic utility. The Board Continuity Caucus supports a narrower emergency guarantee and argues that universal access without expansion controls could exceed evacuation capacity.

Heliostat Bastion is transmitting less power than its generation systems record. Array operators blame transmission loss and aging storage equipment. Erbium auditors believe that power is being diverted before reaching the planetary grid.

A separated habitation block called **Cinder Six** has transmitted evidence that several hundred residents survived its detachment during a late-Lapse-28 Shredder event.

Cinder Six refuses reconnection until the Directorate recognizes its local government, cancels inherited service debt, and guarantees that its residents will not be detained for unauthorized use of emergency systems.

Crown Meridian describes the transmission as encouraging and insufficiently verified.

The Code Reform Delegation has introduced an intersystem proposal to convert Erbium’s Infrastructure Stewardship Seat into a nonvoting technical office.

Several governments support the proposal privately. None has agreed to sponsor it publicly without a guaranteed alternative source of relay maintenance and refined erbium.